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To the Editor-in-Chief *Vestnik RUDN. International Relations* Peoples' Friendship University of Russia (RUDN University), Moscow

Dear Editor,

I am pleased to submit the original research article **"Food Security as Statecraft: Agricultural Exports and Summit Diplomacy in Russia–Africa Relations, 2019–2026"** for consideration for publication in *Vestnik RUDN. International Relations*.

The article examines how Russian agricultural exports function as an instrument of foreign policy in Africa between the Sochi summit of 2019 and the Moscow summit of 2026. Drawing on the literature on food power and economic statecraft, it argues that Russian food diplomacy is best understood as positive, reliability-based statecraft rather than coercive food power, and that its political returns, while real, are diffuse. The article engages with recent research on Russia–Africa relations published in RUDN journals and fits the journal's focus on Russia's relations with the countries of the Global South.

I confirm that:

- the manuscript is original, has not been published previously and is not under consideration by any other journal;
- I am the sole author, hold a master's degree, and have approved the manuscript for submission;
- the manuscript contains 4,152 words including tables and references, within the journal's limit of 6,000 words, and 23 references;
- all data sources are publicly available and cited in the reference list;
- Grok Bot (AI assistant app, October 2026 release; developer: SpaceXAI) helped draft and structure the text and assisted with literature search and reference checking; I directed the work, reviewed and verified all content and take full responsibility for it (full disclosure, including significant prompts, in the AI Use Statement in the Materials and Methods section and on the title page);
- conflicts of interest and funding are disclosed in the Acknowledgements section.

I would be grateful for your consideration of the manuscript.

Sincerely,

/s/ William Aaron Turner

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